



He told me calmly, *"Tu mujh pe bharosa kar* (You should have faith in me), and send the fielder to where I am suggesting..." I followed his advice and bowled in the right areas. We got an edge, and the ball went straight to the fielder. Jassi bhai walked up to me with a smile and said, *"Dekha na! Tu mujh pe bharosa rakh and bowl your best..."* (See, you should have faith in me...)"

From being a member of the Under-19 World Cup-winning team in 2018 to winning the T20 World Cup for the senior team, it has been a long journey. How has the experience been?

Playing in the U-19 World Cup may make you feel like you're at the top of your game, but in reality, it's just the beginning. The real test starts when you play senior cricket. It demands strong character and patience. Unlike in U-19 cricket, there's little room for mistakes in the senior category, so it's crucial to plan well if you want to take wickets and put pressure on the batters. There will be days when you may not get a

wicket despite hard work, so mental strength is important.

A lot of the credit goes to Rahul (Dravid) sir as he tracked my journey since the U-19 days, and that helped me a lot. With him around, it has been relatively easier for me to transition from the U-19 to the senior level. Since he had known me for a long time, it was easy to interact with him, and he was aware of my skill set and my limitations. My family also helped a lot. It's all about adapting to the situation. If you are flexible and not rigid in your approach, it helps you immensely. For instance, in T20s, there will be days when you have to bowl 20 slower balls out of the 24 legal deliveries. And there will be days when you have to back your skills

Backbone of success: Arshdeep with his doting parents, Darshan Singh and Daljeet Kaur, at his residence in Chandigarh. R. V. MOORTHY

and just keep things simple. So, adaptability and flexibility have been key.

Do you approach a game with specific plans for certain batters, or is it more pitch-specific?

I watch old videos of the batters and analyse their strengths and weaknesses. The surface certainly plays a key role, and you need to check what deliveries would be suitable on a particular pitch. We have a lot of team meetings, and they (the team management) tell us

« Inspiring young fans brings me great joy, and I always try to oblige them with selfies and autographs »